

the walker's guide — ANIMA.interact

*you need almost nothing: **wasd** walk · **drag** look · **shift** run · **space**. the writing tells you the rest as you go — the margin at the foot of the frame is the night's only instructions, and they are the author's own sentences, typed at the moment each becomes true.*

this guide exists for walkers who want the night explained, and for the record. part one spoils the mechanics; part two documents why navigation works the way it does. the purest walk is the one that never opens this.

part one — walking the night

the grammar, once

- **wasd** walks, **dragging the mouse** looks, **shift** runs.
- **space** is the only button, and it always means *go on*: it finishes a line that is typing, turns a finished page, lowers a card. held down, it is still one press.
- between places the world dissolves into its own letters and a **chapter page** opens — the destination's name, then the stage's verbatim paragraph from the source writing. space finishes the typing; a beat; space turns the page. (a walked-away page turns itself after a while — the night never waits forever.)
- **choices are conduct**: where you stand, what you face, how long you stay. there are no prompts and no menus — with one deliberate exception in the theatre. declining anything never blocks the night.
- you cannot leave a place before it is done with you. every scene is an island in the text; the night moves when the writing's condition is met, and the way onward is always lit — a pulse, a road, a glow.

the stages, in the writing's order

1. **the gate** — walk the path in; the opening paragraph passes underfoot. Fate is at the gate; the exchange plays as you come near — her lines type in the reading band while her letters lift into the air. **cross the gate line beside her to pay** (the tongue — you will not speak again). read the card she writes (space lowers it). her faded hand may extend mid-exchange: face it up close and stay a moment to take it, or walk on — both are answers, neither is required, and an unmet hand is nobody's answer at all. then **follow the pulsing mushrooms west** to the meadow's edge.
2. **the cloakroom** — the same pulse leads down the aisle of coats; your memories are stored here (the night does this for you). stand still before one coat, facing it, and it is tried on. **walk the aisle through and out the far mouth**, past the counter.
3. **under the Willow** — black cats queue to be registered with the Mage; registered ones leave lettered. one cat is never called: sit close and still beside it and it registers *you* instead. the mouse's sentence runs along the road, brightening westward at reading pace — **walk the road west** past the office.

4. **the strawberry field** — the ride is the exit, and it must be earned. **stand inside the lamp's warm glow and keep him company** through one full tired cycle: slow blinks, the lean, the glow softening — about half a minute of honest waiting. letter-moths gather while you stay. the margin then announces the ride ("my ride arrives at 00:68."). it comes down the road and **stops once, door aglow — stand at the door** and it takes you. missed it? one more cycle of company brings it back. pacing in and out doesn't block anything; the ride just stops a little farther off. it arrives at 00:68 in every version of you.
5. **the show** — you are seated; the head turns, the body stays. watch the trailers, the otters' introduction. the left-most otter stares away the whole time: **hold your gaze on him** a few seconds and you watch his memories with him. the menu comes to you: **a / d** moves the night's only cursor, **space orders** — whatever you choose, the same drink arrives, arriving differently. when the margin says you are drifting off, **stand (w)** and walk down to the stage. at the ledge the night refuses your first step — feet dangle, held breath. **hold still**: the endless stairs float in and complete the leap from their end.
6. **the small wooden boat** — you wake on the sea of standing text. walk to the boat. far out, a white figure dances in the waves: **face her and hold** — the writing's deepest question surfaces. row all you want; this sea writes no wakes. then **be still beside the boat**. stillness is the drift-off: the curtains close, the dream folds, and the night begins again at the gate — remembering who you were.

stuck? the four honest stalls

WHERE	THE NIGHT IS WAITING FOR
the gate	pay at the crossing beside Fate, then walk the mushroom pulse to its last mushroom, west
the strawberry field	a full tired cycle spent inside the glow; then stand at the stopped ride's door
the show	stand (w) after the drifting-off line; at the ledge, stop walking and let the stairs arrive
the boat	stillness beside the boat — stop moving entirely for a few breaths

returning, resetting, process view

- closing the tab keeps your place; reopening resumes your stage — greeted with "why was i here again?"
- `?fresh` on the url = a virgin night (no pass, no folds, every star home).
- `?lab` = process view: free roam, `,` / `.` cycle all scenes, no director.
- `e` toggles the environment source — **model** (an oscillator algorithm) vs **recorded** (the 06.06.26 writing session's own EEG, replayed). keys `1-6` switch typographic registers; `g l v k [ ]` are style toggles.

part two — navigation premises, logic, and reasoning

the navigation system is a constraint system. each rule below is stated as premise → mechanic → reason. together they are why the night has no HUD, no objectives, no map, and no tutorial — and remains walkable.

1 • the writing is the only tutorial. premise: instruction breaks a dream, and the source text already narrates every verb the walker needs. mechanic: the margin voice types the entry's sentences at the moment each becomes true — "follow the glowing mushrooms" types when the trail is yours to follow; "i should get going" when the ride has stopped. reason: story, orientation, and tutorial collapse into one voice, and every instruction carries provenance — the author wrote it.

2 • provenance is the structure. premise: a walker should always know where they are and why — or be made to question it in the writing's own words. mechanic: chapter pages — each stage opens with its verbatim paragraph; the destination's name settles out of the letter-storm; the next place visibly condenses out of the words just read (the in-dissolve reuses the page's own characters). reason: the act structure of the night IS the paragraph structure of the entry; orientation and citation are the same gesture.

3 • one typed voice at a time; no fourth voice. premise: the night must feel like the book noticing you, not software. mechanic: everything on screen is margin, world-matter, or an earned screen moment (the card, the curtains). speech suspends the margin; the margin resumes unread rather than expiring. speaker identity is carried by whose letters are in the air (a being's condensation pulses while its line types) — never a name-tag. in the night, the corner marker even drops the scene id: the world, not the chrome, says where you are. reason: interface discipline is the aesthetic; every additional voice was rejected by name (map, compass, act numerals, objective text, portraits).

4 • choices are conduct, never menus. premise: the piece's argument is the illusion of choice inside the inevitability of encounters. mechanic: three species of choice only — false forks (two ways west, one cloakroom), refusable offers (the faded hand; the night absorbs refusal and advances), and timed inevitabilities (the ride at 00:68 arrives regardless of conduct). choices are read from position, facing, stillness, timing. the fold swaps this night's conduct (*chosen*) into echo; the next night greets who you were — a scold-first Fate, a coat that pauses its sway. plot never branches. reason: the branches converging IS the thesis; choice changes *who you were while the same thing happened*, which is how dreams — and predictive systems — treat a person.

5 • the one cursor exists in order not to matter. premise: the argument lands hardest in the language of choice itself. mechanic: the theatre menu is the night's only conventional picker (a/d + space). whatever is ordered, the same drink arrives — but the *arrival* differs visibly (which side the stork enters, how long the glass is held). reason: a picker that changes the how but never the what performs the thesis inside the walker's own hands; the immediate consequence keeps it legible as an argument rather than a bug.

6 • conduct is not intention. premise (adopted from the cross-model design consult): position, facing, and stillness are also what a person does while reading, recovering, or finding the controls — inferring intent from telemetry is precisely the predictive-system error the work critiques. mechanic: a verdict is recorded only when clearly witnessed (the offer fully formed, plainly met, then deliberately answered). an unmet offer resolves to *unwitnessed*: the night advances, records nothing, and leaves only an '...' — the mark of what the system cannot honestly resolve. every registered verdict is acknowledged materially in the moment (the hand firms warm; closes and lowers; thins to '...'). reason: the piece enforces on itself the honesty it asks of machines.

7 • the pull, not the arrow. premise: wayfinding should be reading. mechanic: the leading element of every stage is luminous text-matter moving at reading pace — the traveling mushroom pulse, the road

sentence whose unread words brighten westward, the lamp lit ahead, the stairs arriving. reason: walking toward the next word is the piece's whole medium made navigational; an arrow would be a fourth voice.

8 • waiting is content. premise: the entry waits ("I waited some time at the street-lamp"), so the walker waits; a dream cannot be speedrun. mechanic: deliberate nothing is made legible by small accumulating beats — the lamp's blinks and deepening lean, moths gathering per cycle, the strawberry rows syncing to his breath; the stillness fold; the held gaze; the leap refused until the stairs complete it. safety valves (page auto-turn, card auto-lower, the ride returning) mean no wait can soft-lock. reason: patience is the mechanic that earns the night's events; the beats exist so waiting reads as the world living, never as the program stalling.

9 • space belongs to the reading surfaces first. premise: navigable prose means reading at your own pace without the night ever locking. mechanic: a strict capture order — page → card → voice → hop; the first press always completes the typing, the second acts; a beat is required between the two so a held key cannot spend both. reason: one button, two legible states, zero modal traps.

10 • progressive liminality, tempered. premise: the walker should progressively enter liminal states as the night deepens. mechanic: an authored dial (stage-indexed, fold-deepened, zero in lab, honesty-labeled MODEL) applies gains only — fog, letter-ground, star depletion ("they've all moved out"), a sleepier margin voice, longer dissolves — deliberately tempered after design review so legibility is never the sacrifice; each scene carries exactly one authored deepening of its own. the recorded EEG remains the body's weather; the dial is narrative time; they multiply and never impersonate one another. reason: depth must be felt without costing the walker the ability to read the night that is deepening around them.

11 • the fold is re-reading. premise: the dream's last line returns to its first. mechanic: the night's end is stillness, not a goal; the fold resets the pass and the jacket, deepens the baseline, and carries conduct forward as echo; resuming mid-night asks the entry's own question — "why was i here again?" reason: a book read twice is a different book because the reader is; the night models that in state.

source of truth for display prose: `source/06.06.26.txt` (+ five cited lines from other journal entries — register in `README.md`). *method and provenance:* `PROCESS.md` . *scene-level rules:* `src/term/scenes/CONTRACT.md` .